



Prompt: Create a writing task for B2-level EFL university students. The focus is rhetorical organization — specifically thesis statements and paragraph structure. Students have already practiced topic sentences and supporting evidence but struggle with writing clear, arguable thesis statements. This task will feed into a final assessed essay at the end of the unit. This is an afternoon class, so the task should be engaging and include a brief collaborative warm-up before individual writing. Students have 45 minutes.

Lesson Plan:

Lesson Title: From Facts to Arguable Claims – Crafting Strong Thesis Statements

Learning Objectives:

By the end of the lesson, students will be able to:

1. Distinguish between a **fact** and an **arguable claim** (thesis).
2. Write a clear, focused thesis statement for an HKDSE-style argumentative prompt.
3. Revise a factual statement into an arguable claim.

Materials:

- Whiteboard / projector
- Handout with prompts and sentence frames
- Mini whiteboards or scratch paper (optional)

Lesson Procedure (50 minutes)

1. Warm-Up: Fact or Claim? (5 mins)

- Display 4 statements on the board:
 1. *Hong Kong has a high population density.* (Fact)
 2. *The Hong Kong government should increase public housing supply.* (Arguable claim)
 3. *Social media is popular among teenagers.* (Fact)
 4. *Schools should ban mobile phones to improve students' focus.* (Arguable claim)
- Ask: *Which statements can be argued for or against? Which are just true?*
- Quick pair-share (1 min), then whole-class vote.
- **Key takeaway:** A thesis must be *debatable*, not a fact.

2. Input & Analysis: What Makes a Thesis Arguable? (10 mins)**

- Define **thesis statement**: *1–2 sentences answering the prompt with a clear position + reason(s).*
- Show a weak (factual) vs. strong (arguable) example for the same HKDSE-style prompt:

Prompt: *Should Hong Kong schools replace traditional exams with continuous assessment?*

- Weak (fact): *Some schools in Hong Kong use continuous assessment.*
- Strong (arguable): *Hong Kong schools should replace traditional exams with continuous assessment because it reduces student stress and encourages deeper learning.*
- Introduce **formula**:
[Position] + [because + reason(s)]
(e.g., *The government should ban single-use plastics because they damage marine ecosystems and threaten public health.*)
- **Check for understanding:** Ask: *Why is the second statement a better thesis?* (It takes a side and gives reasons; someone could disagree.)

3. Guided Practice: Spot the Problem (10 mins)**

- Hand out 3 factual thesis statements (from common HKDSE topics: technology, education, environment).
 - *Social media has both good and bad effects on teenagers.* (Too balanced/factual)
 - *Many people in Hong Kong use online learning platforms.* (Fact)
 - *The government has implemented policies to reduce air pollution.* (Fact)
- In pairs, students:
 1. Identify *why* it's not arguable.
 2. Rewrite it into an arguable thesis using *should/should not* or a clear stance + because.
- Review 2–3 examples on the board.

4. Independent Practice: Write Your Own (15 mins)**

Provide **3 HKDSE-style prompts** (B1–B2 level). Students choose **one** to write a thesis statement for.

Prompts:

1. *Do you agree that schools should ban junk food in canteens?*
2. *Should the Hong Kong government provide free Wi-Fi in all public housing estates?*
3. *Is it better for young people to save money or spend it on experiences like travel?*

Sentence frames for support:

- *I believe that ... because ...*
- *[Position] is necessary because ...*
- *Although some may argue ..., [position] because ...*
- **Differentiation:**
 - B1: Use simpler frame (*X should Y because Z*).
 - B2: Add counter-argument (*While some say ..., I argue ...*).
- Teacher circulates, checks 3–4 students' work, gives immediate oral feedback: *Is this arguable? Could someone disagree?*

5. Peer Feedback & Revision (5 mins)**

- Students swap papers with a partner.
- Peer checklist (displayed on board):
 - ☐ Does it answer the prompt directly?
 - ☐ Is it arguable (not a fact)?
 - ☐ Does it include a reason?
- Partners give one “star” (strength) and one “wish” (improvement).
- Students quickly revise their thesis in the last 2 minutes.

6. Exit Ticket & Wrap-Up (5 mins)**

- On a slip of paper or verbally:
Complete this sentence: *“An arguable thesis statement must be _____, not _____.”*
(Expected: *debatable / a fact*)
- **Final reminder for HKDSE:** *Examiners look for your opinion + reasons – don't just describe what exists.*
- Homework: Choose any HKDSE past paper argumentative question (provided by teacher) and write 3 possible arguable thesis statements.

Teacher Notes for EMI Context (B1–B2):

- Use simple sentence structures and avoid abstract metalanguage (“dialectical,” “contestable”).
- Model aloud and provide written sentence frames.
- Accept emergent language errors if meaning is clear – focus on the concept of “arguable.”
- Use visual cues (✅ fact vs. ✖️ arguable) and gestures to reinforce the difference.